eastern sector. It was also the case that in border negotiations India had been most adamant in refusing to discuss the McMahon Line. On 6 October, when China received India's rejection of Beijing's 3 October proposal for talks on the entire border, the decision for war was more or less made. The military was told, 'If Indian forces attack us, you should hit back fiercely . . . not only repel them, but hit them fiercely and make them hurt.' Marshal Liu Bocheng, who headed the Central Military Commission (CMC), insisted that Chinese forces could not use limited tactics but rather had to 'kill, wound, and capture the enemy'.[74]

China was helped in its war decision-making by American and Soviet diplomacy. Beijing's relations with both powers were tense, but ironically their messaging reassured China in respect of war with India. In May 1962, Zhou asked the Chinese diplomat Wang Bingnan to meet his US counterpart in Warsaw. Since 1955, in the absence of formal diplomatic ties, China and the US had convened a dialogue in Poland to deal with bilateral matters (which, in a further irony, India had helped organize). In 1962, Wang's mission was to assess the US response to a possible Taiwanese invasion of the mainland. Beijing feared that the US might allow the Taiwanese, who were threatening to invade, to mount an attack into southern China from Laos. If so, China would have been at war in the west with India and in the south with Taiwanese forces. In June, to Beijing's relief, the US told Wang that Washington would not support a Taiwanese attack. By July, an international peace agreement had been signed, committing the US not to deploy its troops in Laos, further suggesting that China's southern flank was secure. The US may therefore have unwittingly contributed to China's decision to go to war with India.[75]

The Soviet role was less unwitting. Moscow and Beijing had been drifting apart ideologically and strategically since the late 1950s, but in October 1962 as the Cuban missile crisis loomed, the Soviets shifted ground in the India–China quarrel. In 1959, Khrushchev had had some harsh words for Mao and Zhou on their handling of Tibet and India. But by October 1962, knowing that the emplacement of nuclear weapons in Cuba was likely to develop into a crisis with Washington, Moscow wanted to firm